

Episode 185: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 12

Recently, I've finally (finally!) started paying attention to my weight, and I'm properly getting on the scale every morning. This morning as I write this it's 81.2 kilogrammemes. I've gained a bit lately. Plus 1 kilogramme, perhaps due to that Chinese food banquet the other day. Come to think of it, last month when I had yakiniku three days in one week, I was surprised when I suddenly gained 2-3 kilogrammemes (laugh). But somehow I'm keeping it under 80 kilogrammemes.

Incidentally, based on the standard weight calculation for my height, I need to lose another 10 kilogrammemes (laugh).

Our work involves sitting for long periods, so if you're a bit careless your weight increases immediately. Frequent eating out is also one cause. Recently I've shifted the centre of studio meals to bread + milk. I'm controlling to avoid greasy things as much as possible. This has settled things down considerably. Aim for the dream 70-kilogramme range!

But you know, when stress builds up, I desperately want to eat greasy things (wry laugh). Now then.

Episode 10: "Because I Like You" Storyboard, Direction & Animation Director/Goto Keiji (後藤圭二), Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Shoma, carried to the hospital after a car accident, is kidnapped by someone, and in exchange for his person, they demand the half of the diary remaining in Ringo's hands. Kanba confronts the criminal with a fake diary and chases the criminal into a mysterious space within the hospital. Meanwhile, Ringo is demanded to give the real diary to the criminal and ends up handing it over. Such was Episode 10.

Episode 10 was an episode where Goto Keiji handled storyboard, direction, rough animation, and animation director by himself. It was an episode he steadily drew alone at the seat furthest back in the staff room.

"Togou General Hospital," which would become one of the important stages for the story from here on, debuts in this episode, but Episode 9's Takeuchi Nobuyuki was in charge of design. All the visuals of the mysterious internal space that Kanba wanders into were Takeuchi's responsibility. The exterior motif is an actual building called the Pompidou Centre in Paris. Using that as reference, he skillfully arranged it into a uniquely distinctive atmosphere.

Actually, throughout *Mawaru Penguindrum*, we've referenced real building designs in many places. During art setting meetings, thick photo books of world architectural design and Art Deco photo books were pulled out countless times, flipping through their pages or looking at images searched online. Unexpected architectural structures were referenced in unexpected scenes. So every episode, I looked forward to backgrounds coming up from the art team.

Incidentally, background completion checks were done for almost every episode by the assigned director, Chief Director Nakamura, and myself. Of course, for checks of important points that had been discussed in direction meetings, Director Ikuhara and Assistant Director Yamazaki also attended. Within the studio, my work monitor became the standard for screen brightness and colour tone, and checks were done around my desk and monitor late at night. Of course, art board checks were the same. At those times, with art staff included, we'd have meetings around my desk while looking at the screen, discussing this and that.

When background completion timing was around midnight, we often couldn't catch the last train. Particularly in the latter half of the series, we quite frequently missed the last train and worked until morning (laugh).

So, about that Togou General Hospital - in Episode 10 we decided to "not show the overall exterior yet," so we devised the storyboard to show only partial views like the upper part of the building, patient room exteriors, and parking lot.

And one character who appeared while we "didn't show the full picture yet" - the figure in the parking lot who picks up the diary and leaves, yes, Renjaku (連雀) also made her first appearance in this episode. But still just a silhouette. Actually, this figure was a male "Natsume family's old butler" until the middle of producing this episode. Then suddenly in Episode 16 "Renjaku's" appearance was decided, and we urgently had to create her design. Then it became "this person at this time is probably Renjaku," so we redrew two cuts to be Renjaku. However, Renjaku's colours weren't decided yet at this time, and the close-up cut of the hand picking up the diary was, well, an evening scene, so somewhat atmospheric (laugh).

Now, for Episode 10's colour design, the basics were still matching art space and temporal settings. We patiently held back various things until the coming "story turning point" of Episodes 11 and 12. ...However, the mysterious hospital interior space that switches in the rooftop scene - in a sense real but somehow unreal imagery. In that mysterious space, we really needed to consider something visual or it wouldn't settle properly. So after trying various things, I personally used the technique of "changing main line colours imagistically" that I'd been saving for after the "story turning point." This time I picked up the blue atmosphere used in that scene's background and made the main lines blue-toned. I used it from where Kanba wakes up on the rooftop, going down the stairs to the front of the underground operating room (?).

The night vision goggle view of the operating room's darkness - well, the standard reference for this kind of scene is the movie *The Silence of the Lambs*. I myself have done this in various works - how many times is this? (laugh). For this scene, the green colour change is not photography filter work but properly creating it green with art + colouring. The reason being that if you apply a green filter over a normally created screen, characters get buried in the background and become hard to see. Real night vision goggles might make screens look that way, but in this scene the character's

(Kanba's) expression and performance must be properly visible, so against the background's green colour tone, I shifted the character colouring's hue slightly and added somewhat yellow colour tones. Then photography added noise and such over that to create that screen.

Another subtle failure in such dark performance. The Kanba×Masako kiss scene was fine in the close-up cut, but in the subsequent wide shot, Kanba×Masako in the background blended too much with the dark BG, and only the Esmeralda×#1 kiss scene in the foreground stood out on screen (laugh). Hmm, dark scenes are indeed difficult to balance.

(12.06.26)